

RMS visits a computer centre for the poor

Ambedkar Community Computer Centre (AC3) is situated in a slum in New Gurupampalaya in Bannerghatta Road, Bangalore. In the IT city of multinationals, it is only one of the many slums. On December 13, 2008, this slum had a unique visitor, famous the world over as the founder of the Free Software Foundation. Richard M Stallman's visit turned the attention of IT professionals and media persons to this otherwise 'invisible' slum.

AC3 was set up by members of Stree Jagruthi Samithi, volunteers from AID (Association for India's Development) and by some Free Software Volunteers working in the IT industry.

The idea of setting up the centre was to equip the poor children in the nearby area with the basic computer skills using quality software, which is shareable and available free of cost. The centre uses free software tools on GNU/Linux to teach and impart computer knowledge to the children. The effort is now showing results and the children have shown great enthusiasm. One of the children, Mani, who studies in Class 9, has created beautiful pictures using The GIMP. His pictures got a huge response from the exhibition conducted during the Free Software National Conference held in Cochin in November 2008. Amazed by Mani's pictures, RMS agreed to visit AC3 and interact with the children for a few minutes.

During his visit, RMS inaugurated Mani's painting exhibition and released a book written by children on the basis of their experience in this computing centre. Sarasu, who is from the slum area and teaches kids at the computing centre, presented a talk about AC3 and the work it is doing for the poor. RMS made two corrections to the presentation. He emphasised that free software is not the alternative, but it is the right one. He also added that instead of saying "a few success stories" the presentation should say "a great success story" as this community computing centre is doing a great job.

There were also some cultural events presented by the slum dwellers, after which, RMS interacted with the audience and addressed their questions. Here is an extract from Stallman's speech:

"I am honoured to be here in the community computer centre that is in the name of Dr BR Ambedkar. I have read



about Ambedkar and I was inspired by the work he has done for the dalit people in India. There are many issues among the poor and marginalised in India that are more important than using free software. But, free software is one of the tools that helps the poor and the dalits to resolve some of the issues they are facing. Poor people can't afford proprietary software and free software helps them get access to computers. While proprietary software companies are like the colonial rulers who exploited the masses, free software is freedom and liberation. The Ambedkar Community Computer Centre is a model for the other parts of India in the way it gives access to computers to the poor without compromising their freedom. The Ambedkar Community Centre is doing a great job by empowering the poor with knowledge of free software."

It was a memorable experience for the people in the slum. They were all inspired by the visit of RMS to spread the message of free software and also take the centre to the next level.

By: Sreejith G.S.

The author is a free software supporter and is part of the Ambedkar Community Computer Centre team. He works as a technical writer at Sun Microsystems.

Q Right, so how self-sustaining is it?

Well, your guess is as good as mine. But I can see there are thousands of free software activists. There are other people who could tell you the same things that I can tell you, but there are people who would listen when I say it and they perhaps won't when other people say the same thing, because my name is better known now. Well, we make use of that for the better cause.

Q What are you doing to ensure that your movement is self sustaining?

Well, I do my best. Basically, what is going to increase our chances? Having more people who are free software activists and who look for ways to be better activists—

who look for ways to spread the idea of the movement and try to learn to do it the best they can. That's how they will be the same sort of person that I am now.

Well, I hope the force of free software activists keeps growing... 

Interview by Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.